

In other words, short-term stress caused participants not only to abandon their long-term health goals, but their brain activity was similarly altered. If you remember back to [Chapter 7](#), these are the regions of the brain we talked about that reduced individuals' self-control over food choices.

We already know from our discussions in previous chapters that most of us suffer from a lack of self-control. If we understand that even moderate stressors will influence our self-control and choices, it becomes imperative to create systems and habits that ensure we don't financially sabotage when these stressors arrive. Because they will.

Of course, one of the issues when it comes to money and stress is that for many of us, our finances alone are an enormous source of stress.

According to the annual 'Stress & Wellbeing' report by the Australian Psychological Society, finances regularly top our list of worries or stressors. 'Australians' worries about money have not abated. Financial issues are rated as the top cause of stress over the five years [from 2011–2015]'. In other words, never mind the increase in modern life stressors generally; our finances alone can lead to increased stress.

This financial stress can adversely affect our health and our ability to think rationally and calmly and to make smart financial decisions. A 2013 paper published by Anandi Mani, Sendhil Mullainathan, Eldar Shafir and Jiaying Zhao from Princeton University reported that financial stress caused participants to perform worse on common comprehension, intelligence and logic tests. On average, those in the stress group had a drop in testing results akin to a 13-point drop in IQ or the loss of an entire night's sleep.

Financial stress may differ depending on your age and demographic. According to a 2017 Bank of America Merrill Lynch Workplace Benefits Report, millennials are twice as likely as baby boomers to report that stress interferes with work with nearly 6 in 10 believing that financial stress is negatively affecting their health. In Australia, despite over two decades of GDP growth, the Centre for Social Impact in their report 'Financial Resilience in Australia 2016', reported that 'the overall level of financial resilience in Australia decreased between 2015 to 2016 ... 2.4 million adults were financially vulnerable and there was a significant decrease in the proportion who were financially secure (35.7% to 31.2%)'.